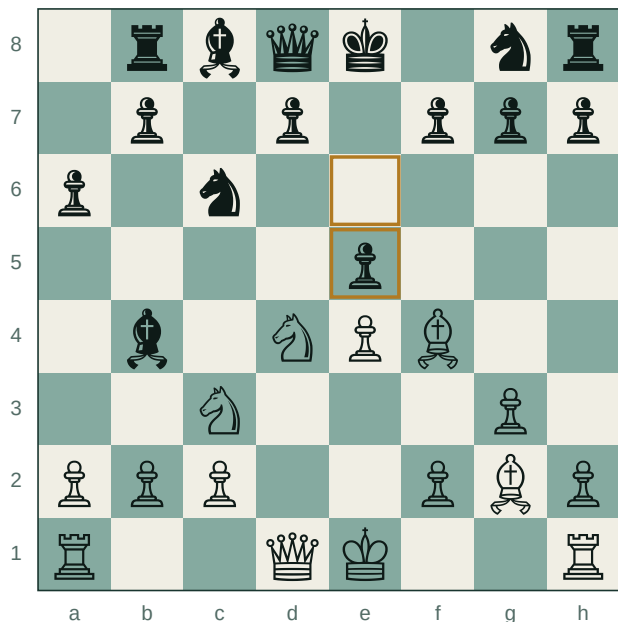


Capture the defender: White, move 9

Capture the defender

White to move



Previous move: 8...e5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

9. Nxc6 bxc6 10. Bxe5

9.Nxc6 The knight captures the knight on c6. From c6 it attacks queen on d8, rook on b8 and bishop on b4. Recorded reply: **9...bxc6**.

10.Bxe5 The bishop captures the pawn on e5.

At the end, nominal material is White 35 / Black 34 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +1: the balance goes from +0 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on e8. Geometrically undefended: rook on h8. Check for tactical protection.